



Many galaxies are found in galaxy clusters, with thousands of members. Our galaxy, the Milky Way, belongs to a cluster of more than 50 galaxies called the Local Group.

Great galaxies

A galaxy is a family of stars, gas, and dust held together by gravity. Much of a galaxy is empty space, with distances between each star that are hard to imagine.

Two galaxies may sometimes collide. This image shows two spiral galaxies that have moved together.



A guide to galaxies

Galaxies differ enormously in size, shape, and mass, but they do fall into a basic pattern, depending on their shape (though we don't know what gives them a particular shape!).



Spiral galaxies

These disc-shaped galaxies spin slowly. They look a bit like whirlpools, and often have two arms that curl out from a central bulge. The Messier 74 is an example of a spiral galaxy.



Barred spiral galaxies

Barred spiral galaxies have arms that wind out from the ends of a central bar of stars rather than from the core. The Milky Way is an example of a barred spiral galaxy.